

UTT Chapter 16 Assignment

Hello there!

Best break idea ever? Hiking the Appalachian Trail with Mark, Nathan, and Muhammad. With backpacks, trail mix, and sleeping bags in tow, we spent about ten days on the trail. It was probably the most adventurous retreat I have ever taken. We caught our own food, cooked it over a campfire, and slept under the stars. It was an amazing bonding experience. We saw a lot of wildlife and flora that Nathan, our resident biologist, identified for us. Good thing he was there, because I almost ate poisonous berries! It was a welcome break from the stress of classes and campaigning.

Speaking of classes, my professors are already talking about final papers and exams. For my macroeconomics class, the students are required to write a paper on what they think is the ideal economic system. Before I began the class, I heard that the free market system was the most ideal. My professor, however, seemed to favor a lot of government intervention to help with the distribution of wealth. He didn't actually say he favored socialism, but I believe that is his leaning. He portrayed capitalism as a greedy, manipulative system where the rich oppress everyone else. Going into this final paper, I no longer have any idea which economic system is the most biblical. Nathan and I were talking about it for a while during the hike, but he didn't help me out too much. If I understood him correctly, he believed that we all have the potential to become rich and successful if we only ask the universe!

Hearing us talk about economics, Mark jumped right into the conversation. He said that a market-oriented economy, like capitalism, is a chaotic system only useful for exploiting the poor. He talked about socialism as the solution. Somehow, socialism will lead to the establishment of communism. Mark even suggested that socialism is consistent with the teachings of Christianity. I'm not sure how that works exactly, but we are called to care for the poor, right?

I know Sarah and Mark sometimes agree on these worldview matters. Have you heard anything about this in your worldview class? **What is the Secularist view of economics?** Also, **what is the Marxist view?**

Nathan's views were probably the most confusing. **What is the role of economics in New Spirituality?** Perhaps my biggest concern is not knowing which economic system is the most consistent with Christianity. I can't remember if economics is even addressed in the Bible. **Are there any biblical principles of economics, and if so, what are they?**

Thanks for all your help. You are a lifesaver! Boy, am I glad that you had a worldview class to help me out with all this. Hopefully I will have time to write again soon. With finals and elections coming up, I'm not sure I will even have time to sleep!

See ya later!

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is the Secularist view of economics?

Secularists represent a wide variety of economic policies including capitalism, socialism, and a combination of the two called **economic interventionism**—an economic system in which the government influences aspects of a market economy in an attempt to improve the public good. Although some Secularists recognize the failure of socialism, most today advocate for an economic system steeped in government invention. As many Secularists see it, the free market system is the source of economic disparity. Secularists reduce economic equality to *physical* monetary outcomes and not equal opportunity for all. And since it is assumed that human beings are basically good, then it must be our society that has led people astray. It is assumed that the poor have less because the rich have taken advantage of those less fortunate. Many Secularists believe that once finances have been fairly reallocated, the poor will have a greater incentive to contribute, crime and antisocial behavior will diminish, and society will be better for everyone. [16.5]

2. What is the Marxist view of economics?

Marxism is also critical of the free market system, and it advocates socialism outright. **Socialism** is an economic system in which citizens forfeit property rights in exchange for a central planning authority that attempts to provide economic stability by controlling the distribution of goods and labor. According to Marxism, socialism is just an intermediate step on the road toward a communist utopia. Until communism can be achieved, the state must control every aspect of the economy from production to distribution. Marxists contend that socialism will eventually wash away the evils of capitalism, freeing humanity to achieve the perfection promised by Marxism. Eventually, economic intervention will become unnecessary and the need for government will ultimately fade away. [16.6]

3. What is the role of economics in New Spirituality?

New Spirituality focuses on tapping into the higher consciousness; consciousness is all that is real. According to New Spiritualists, we can transform human society by reconnecting to the divine essence of the universe. According to the notion of **universal enlightened production**, an individual's financial success is directly proportional to his or her level of enlightenment. New Spiritualists are not all that concerned with the subject of economics, but they do believe that economic problems are reducible to a spiritual problem. If we can concentrate on achieving higher consciousness, we will make wise financial decisions, generate wealth, and avoid the perils of poverty. [16.8]

4. Are there any biblical principles of economics and, if so, what are they?

The principles we find in Scripture include stewardship, private property, work, trust, competition, and social justice. **Biblical stewardship** is the act of managing and caring for resources that ultimately belong to God. This act of stewardship, then, is grounded in the principles of hard work and private property.

A less obvious biblical principle of economics is competition, which finds its foundation in the biblical command to work hard and produce the best product at the best price. This creates goods that can benefit the poor, and it also reinforces our self-worth and dignity.

Another biblical principle is social justice, which requires equality *before the law* rather than equality of income or ability. Impartiality, not equality, is the key to a biblical understanding of social justice. In the end, Christians should support the system of economics that goes beyond good intentions and promotes compassionate and just outcomes, good government, freedom, and stewardship. [16.10]